



BUSINESS CASE

HorizonLink Platform

A Phased Digital Transformation for Sustainable Professional Interaction

Prepared by: Grace Nguyen
Victoria University of Wellington



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Executive Summary

HorizonLink is a transformative digital platform designed to address the unsustainability and inequity of the traditional professional interaction ecosystem. Conventional conferences and meetings depend heavily on high-carbon travel, producing thousands of tonnes of CO₂ and imposing substantial financial and time costs. These events are episodic, expensive, and exclusive, limiting participation, restricting global collaboration, and reinforcing inequality in career development.

HorizonLink redefines professional interaction as a continuous, inclusive, and low-carbon experience, delivered through three integrated modules:

- Pulse: Enables daily, habit-forming professional engagement and social capital growth.
- Sphere: Offers immersive collaboration via extended-reality (XR) environments that replace physical travel.
- Blueprint: Provides data-driven sustainability analytics for planning hybrid and low-carbon events.

HorizonLink creates measurable Triple Bottom Line benefits:

- Economic: Converts unpredictable event revenues and travel expenses into scalable, recurring SaaS and transaction-based income.
- Environmental: Reduces aviation emissions by quantifying avoided carbon using Life Cycle Assessment metrics and applying Green Computing standards to ensure credibility.
- Social: Expands equitable access for early-career professionals and global teams, embedding Ethical Persuasive Design that sustains engagement while preserving user autonomy.

A hybrid of freemium SaaS subscriptions, transaction fees, licensing, and data partnerships ensures recurring revenue and ethical scalability. Strategic alliances with professional associations, technology vendors, and green fintechs extend HorizonLink's reach and technical capacity. The Circle Mapping growth strategy begins with low-risk adoption among professional associations (Pulse), then scales to corporate clients and ESG-focused organisations (Sphere), and finally to the broader MICE industry, government, and education sectors (Blueprint).

HorizonLink is not simply a virtual event platform; it is a comprehensive digital transformation strategy for sustainable professional collaboration. Immediate investment and partnership funding for Phase 1 (Pulse) are recommended to build critical mass, validate the model, and generate the financial and reputational capital required to scale Sphere and Blueprint, positioning HorizonLink as the global benchmark for sustainable professional connection.



1. Project Description & Scope

HorizonLink is an integrated digital platform designed to transform the professional interaction ecosystem from travel-intensive, episodic events into a continuous, low-impact, multi-layered digital engagement platform. The project consists of three modules (Pulse, Sphere, and Blueprint) delivered in phases to achieve sustainable behavioural change, inclusive participation, and measurable Triple Bottom Line (TBL) outcomes.

2. Goals & Objectives

1. Reduce CO₂ emissions from professional interactions by 50% within five years.
2. Enable professionals to build and verify social capital through measurable digital participation.
3. Provide organisations with verifiable sustainability data and new digital revenue streams.
4. Deliver TBL value for users, associations, employers, and the planet.
5. Achieve adoption across ten major professional associations within two years of launch.

3. Key Stakeholders

HorizonLink creates shared value for multiple stakeholders within the professional ecosystem:

- Professionals: Seek affordable development, recognition, and meaningful collaboration.
- Employers and Associations: Require engagement, retention, and cost-effective event models.
- Technology Partners: Supply AI, analytics, and immersive tools to enable innovation.
- Sustainability Partners: Provide carbon tracking and impact analytics.
- The Planet: The ultimate beneficiary through reduced emissions and waste.

Each stakeholder contributes to and benefits from HorizonLink's network effects, driving collective progress toward sustainable professional ecosystems.

4. Problem Statement

Traditional professional interactions, dominated by in-person conferences, generate massive carbon emissions, inequitable access, high financial costs, and hidden economic burdens. Despite sustainability awareness, digital alternatives have failed to replicate the engagement, trust, and recognition depth of physical gatherings. This



persistent “experience gap”, reinforced by cultural inertia and short-term priorities, locks professional communities into unsustainable practices and threatens the future viability of global professional connections and collaboration.

5. Proposal & Analysis

5.1. Summary of the Innovation

HorizonLink represents a Digital Transformation initiative altering the value creation path of the global MICE sector. Rather than digitising traditional conferences, it operates as a multi-sided Platform Business Model¹ (see Appendix A), forming an ethically designed digital ecosystem. This connects professionals (users), content creators (speakers/educators), and organisations (associations/employers), enabling continuous, high-value engagement.

The platform’s phased approach ensures an evolutionary, not disruptive, transformation designed to overcome structural barriers and build Dynamic Capabilities².

- **Phase 1: Pulse - Continuous Professional Engagement**

Pulse lays the foundation by enabling asynchronous, daily interactions that cultivate mobilised social capital³ - active connections that generate opportunities, knowledge, and visibility (see Appendix B). Using the Hook Model and gamified recognition, Pulse turns participation into a meaningful habit. Users share updates, join topic circles, and track their Social Capital Index (SCI), a data-driven measure of network strength and engagement. This shifts professional development from passive event attendance to active, sustained involvement.

- **Phase 2: Sphere - Immersive Collaboration**

Sphere builds on Pulse by introducing an immersive collaboration layer powered by Metaverse and XR technologies, supporting high-fidelity virtual workshops, negotiations, and training (see Appendix C).

Sphere differentiates itself from typical virtual meeting tools through:

- High emotional fidelity via realistic avatars, spatial audio, and shared 3D environments.

¹ Zhu, F., & Nathan, F. (2016). Products to Platforms: Making the Leap. *Harvard Business Review*, 94(4), 72–78. <https://hbr.org/2016/04/products-to-platforms-making-the-leap>

² Vial, G. (2019). Understanding digital transformation: A review and a research agenda. *The Journal of Strategic Information Systems*, 28(2), 118-144.

<https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0963868717302196>

³ Zhao, H.H., Liu, S., Zheng, X., Li, N., Yiu, S., & Liu, X. (2025). Mobilized social capital and career success: A model of retrieval, referral, and reinforcement. *Journal of Vocational Behaviour*, 157(104094), 1-18. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jvb.2025.104094>



- Ethical design that avoids addictive patterns common in immersive tech.
- Quantified sustainability, showing carbon savings from virtual meetings.

It uses Nudge Plus techniques to promote environmental responsibility and well-being. Inclusive by design, Sphere reduces access barriers for underrepresented groups often excluded from in-person events.

- **Phase 3: Blueprint - Sustainable Event Optimisation**

Blueprint is the strategic analytics layer guiding sustainable event design (see Appendix D). Based on the TBL framework⁴, Blueprint integrates three layers of analysis:

- Economic Layer: Tracks ROI across digital and physical formats.
- Environmental Layer: Measures carbon, energy, and material savings using Life Cycle Assessment (LCA).
- Social Layer: Assesses inclusivity, accessibility, and participant well-being.

Acting as a boundary object, Blueprint fosters collaboration among finance, sustainability, and event teams. Its interactive dashboards and ethical defaults help planners make data-informed, sustainable decisions without compromising engagement quality.

5.2. Target Customers and Users

HorizonLink's design is grounded in a deep understanding of its initial and next-layer customer groups, derived from problem analysis and stakeholder mapping (See Appendix E).

- **Initial Target Customers**

The primary early adopters are professional associations and academic societies, especially those in geographically isolated regions such as New Zealand and Australia, where travel to international conferences is costly and carbon-intensive. These organisations seek to maintain engagement and learning quality without losing professional credibility or networking depth. For them, Pulse provides continuous engagement and measurable value, while Blueprint supports transparent, data-driven planning for hybrid events.

- **Next-Layer Customers**

As HorizonLink scales, its target customers expand to include corporate learning divisions, consulting firms, and multinational corporations with strong ESG (Environmental, Social, and Governance) reporting obligations and distributed teams.

⁴ Joyce, A. & Paquin, R. L. (2016). The triple layered business model canvas: A tool to design more sustainable business models. *Journal of Cleaner Production*, 135, 1474-1486.
<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jclepro.2016.06.067>



These organisations use Sphere for immersive, cross-border collaboration and Blueprint for sustainability reporting and event optimisation.

User persona was used to represent these target groups with different user motivations and pain points. These include:

- Elle, an early-career academic seeking recognition and low-cost access to global professional networks.
- Joyce, an association executive managing retention and sustainability goals.
- Dr Smith, a corporate strategist driving sustainable global collaboration.
- Mei, an event planner in the MICE industry optimising hybrid event logistics through the Blueprint module.

Each persona reflects a unique dimension of HorizonLink's value proposition and guides the functional and ethical design of its modules. They validate that the platform responds not only to organisational sustainability imperatives but also to the lived experiences of professionals navigating an increasingly hybrid work and learning ecosystem.

5.3. Vision Statement

HorizonLink envisions a world where professional growth and collaboration transcend borders, barriers, and emissions by redefining success through equity, connection, and planetary care, and transforming how communities connect, learn, and lead toward a sustainable future.

5.4. Value Proposition for Key Stakeholders

HorizonLink's value proposition is structured around a multi-sided platform ecosystem addressing user needs and delivering value across economic, social, and environmental dimensions (see Appendix F). Each stakeholder group performs distinct yet interdependent roles in co-creating value. This integrated approach ensures the platform's innovation not only enhances engagement and inclusivity but also advances environmental sustainability.

For professionals, the Pulse module enables continuous engagement, allowing users to build and display measurable social capital through habit-forming digital interactions. It provides accessible career growth without costly travel.

For associations and event organisers, the Blueprint module offers data-driven tools to design and optimise hybrid events using TBL metrics. It improves member retention, tracks engagement, and demonstrates verifiable sustainability outcomes.

For employers and corporate clients, the Sphere module provides an immersive collaboration space that replaces high-carbon business travel with high-fidelity, virtual interaction. It supports ESG reporting through real-time carbon avoidance metrics and enhances team productivity.



For the planet, HorizonLink contributes directly to decarbonisation by replacing high-emission travel with low-carbon digital engagement. The platform quantifies carbon avoidance and resource efficiency, ensuring verifiable sustainability impact. It transforms professional interaction into an activity that supports planetary boundaries.

5.5. Partners

HorizonLink's success relies on forming strategic partnerships that extend its external Integrative Capabilities⁵ across technology, sustainability, and professional ecosystems. These partners provide the expertise, credibility, and infrastructure required to deliver value across all three modules while benefiting directly from the platform's innovation and growth:

- **Professional Associations:** Associations and academic societies provide the initial large Social Network and critical mass of users. Their participation mitigates the risk of platform desertion and market entry barriers and ensures network effects develop. In return, they gain tools for member engagement, retention, and sustainability reporting, reinforcing their long-term relevance in an evolving digital ecosystem.
- **Technology Partners (AI, VR/AR Providers):** Technology vendors are essential for delivering Sphere's high-fidelity immersive collaboration and Pulse's AI-driven personalisation. These partners provide the necessary infrastructure and knowledge of emerging technologies. These partners benefit from co-developing scalable, ethical applications of emerging technologies, expanding their reach into professional and corporate learning markets.
- **Sustainability and Green Fintech Partners:** Fintech and analytics firms specialising in carbon measurement and impact tracking integrate into the platform, enabling transparent, verifiable sustainability reporting. HorizonLink gains technical credibility and real-time environmental data, while partners access new B2B markets and demonstrate leadership in digital sustainability solutions.

5.6. Benefit & Impact Analysis

HorizonLink delivers value across economic, environmental, and social layers, ensuring benefits to customers, stakeholders, and the planet.

- **Economic:** By shifting from one-off conferences to a recurring subscription and licensing model, HorizonLink stabilises revenue streams for associations while reducing employers' travel spend and productivity losses. Predictable income

⁵ Vial, G. (2019). Understanding digital transformation: A review and a research agenda. *The Journal of Strategic Information Systems*, 28(2), 118-144.

<https://www.sciencedirect.com/science/article/abs/pii/S0963868717302196>



replaces event-dependent uncertainty, while data-driven insights and consulting create new revenue opportunities.

- **Environmental:** The platform directly reduces aviation-related emissions by replacing travel-intensive meetings with digital engagement. Blueprint (Phase 3) integrates LCA to measure carbon, energy, and material savings, enabling transparent reporting of avoided emissions. This moves sustainability from aspirational claims to verifiable outcomes, addressing stakeholder scrutiny and ESG obligations.
- **Social:** HorizonLink expands participation by lowering geographic and financial barriers, particularly benefiting early-career academics, women, and underrepresented groups. Continuous engagement (Pulse) reduces reliance on sporadic events and supports equitable Social Capital building. By reducing travel fatigue and time away from family, the platform enhances well-being and inclusivity.

These impacts position HorizonLink as a transformative model, creating professional value while preserving long-term planetary and societal needs.

5.7. Monetisation Plan

HorizonLink adopts a phased monetisation strategy that evolves alongside the platform's functionality and maturity:

1. Phase 1 (Pulse) - Freemium + Subscription-Based SaaS (B2B and B2C):

The Pulse module operates under a Software-as-a-Service (SaaS) model.

- **Freemium Access (B2C):** Individual professionals join free to access core networking features, building early network effects and user engagement.
- **Premium Subscription (B2B):** Organisations (e.g., associations, universities, employers) purchase tiered subscriptions based on user volume or analytics depth. Premium access unlocks advanced benchmarking and engagement dashboards.
- **Data Monetisation:** Anonymised activity data (e.g., engagement trends, skill insights) is sold as Data-as-a-Service (DaaS) to inform workforce development and organisational learning strategies.

2. Phase 2 (Sphere) - Transaction-Based and Licensing (B2B):

Sphere generates revenue through immersive, high-value digital interactions:

- **Transaction-Based Fees (Pay-Per-Use):** Organisations pay per immersive event or participant hour (e.g., virtual workshops or simulations), reflecting usage-based value.



- **Licensing Customised Virtual Spaces:** Corporations and associations license branded, persistent virtual environments (e.g., a “Virtual Sustainability Campus”). These serve as digital offices or networking hubs, generating recurring annual or semi-annual fees.

3. Phase 3 (Blueprint) - SaaS Licensing + Consulting Services:

The Blueprint module generates high-margin revenue by offering a strategic analytics platform for sustainability planning:

- **SaaS Licensing:** Recurring fees for access to the proprietary Triple Layered Business Model Canvas (TLBMC) and LCA tools.
- **Consulting and Implementation Services:** Expert support for integrating TBL metrics into hybrid event strategies for associations and sustainability teams.

4. Secondary Revenue Streams:

- **Data Products:** Aggregated insights from all modules are licensed to institutions, employers, and policy bodies for benchmarking engagement, carbon impact, and inclusivity. This creates an additional B2B data economy layer aligned with ethical governance standards (GDPR, transparency by design).
- **Partnership Revenue:** Co-branded collaborations with sustainability partners, fintechs, or universities sponsor themed challenges or learning pathways (e.g., “Net-Zero Leadership Week powered by HSBC”). These partnerships create shared marketing visibility and generate additional sponsorship income.

5.8. Costs & Funding Considerations

The initial investment for HorizonLink focuses on platform development, AI integration, and ethical governance systems to ensure scalability and trust. Key investment areas include:

- Phase 1 (Pulse): Development of the core platform architecture, behavioural design features, and data analytics engine to enable continuous engagement.
- Phase 2 (Sphere): R&D for immersive VR/AR collaboration, infrastructure scaling, and interoperability to support high-fidelity interaction.
- Phase 3 (Blueprint): Development of the sustainability analytics layer, integrating TBL metrics and LCA dashboards.

Ongoing costs include cloud infrastructure, compliance audits, partnership management, and continuous R&D for system upgrades.



In terms of funding sources, initial capital will be sought from impact investors, professional association partnerships, and sustainability innovation grants. Future phases will be sustained through subscription and consulting revenue streams.

Continuing with traditional, travel-based conferences incurs escalating financial costs (venues, travel, accommodation), social inequity (limited accessibility), and environmental harm (high emissions). In contrast, HorizonLink's digital model represents a strategic investment that transforms recurring travel expenditure into scalable, low-carbon, and inclusive digital engagement that creates measurable value for organisations, professionals, and the planet.

5.9. Risk Analysis

HorizonLink operates within a rapidly evolving digital ecosystem where technological, ethical, and adoption-related risks must be carefully managed to ensure credibility, scalability, and sustained value creation.

Major Risk	Description/Challenge	Mitigation Strategy
Adoption & Engagement Risk	Cultural inertia and user hesitation to shift from face-to-face conferences to digital engagement. Risk of slow uptake and low network effects.	Strategic partnerships with professional associations to secure an initial user base; apply Hook Model and gamified engagement to build sustained habits; iterative platform design through users' feedback loop to enhance perceived value.
Ethical & Regulatory Risk	Potential misuse of behavioural or personal data, algorithmic opacity, or perception of manipulation (dark patterns) could erode user trust.	Embed Ethical Design principles and Nudge Plus mechanisms to ensure transparency, user autonomy, and informed consent; conduct regular ethical AI and data audits.
Technical & Interoperability Risk	High technical complexity of integrating VR/AR technologies (Sphere) and maintaining low-latency, secure environments.	Develop a modular, cloud-native architecture with scalable APIs and edge computing; collaborate with established XR/AI vendors to ensure system reliability.
Sustainability Integrity Risk	Accusations of "greenwashing" due to ICT energy use undermining sustainability claims.	Integrate Life Cycle Assessment verification, Green Computing principles, and third-party sustainability audits within Blueprint reporting.
Monetisation & Competition Risk	Balancing free vs. premium experiences; competition with large incumbents (e.g., LinkedIn).	Maintain differentiated value (scientific credibility, sustainability focus); introduce co-branded partnerships and sponsor incentives to sustain revenue diversity.



6. Solution Requirements

6.1. High-Level Requirements

HorizonLink must bridge the intention–action gap between sustainability awareness and professional behaviour. The platform shall deliver a seamless, ethically designed experience across modules, each meeting specific user and stakeholder goals.

1. **Pulse:** Supports daily professional interaction and community building through gamified and habit-forming systems. Users (e.g., early-career academics like Elle) can engage in discussions, share insights, endorse peers, and track measurable growth via their SCI.
2. **Sphere:** Provides realistic, high-value collaboration experiences for distributed teams using Extended Reality (XR) and Metaverse technologies. Corporate strategists (e.g., Joyce) can host workshops, negotiations, or training sessions in 3D environments, achieving the emotional fidelity of in-person interaction while quantifying the carbon saved.
3. **Blueprint:** Provides organisational users (e.g., Mei, an event planner) with a strategic analytics layer for designing hybrid or virtual events aligned with the TBL. It integrates LCA metrics, allowing planners to visualise the environmental, social, and economic impact of their decisions.

6.2. Persuasive Behavioural Designs and Ethical Frameworks

HorizonLink applies Persuasive Systems Design⁶ and the Hook Model⁷ to shape user behaviour ethically, while adhering to Ethical Design principles⁸ to ensure engagement translates into sustained, positive change without manipulation. Each module integrates these frameworks differently to align with user motivations and the platform’s sustainability objectives.

1. Pulse – Habit Formation through Positive Reinforcement

Pulse transforms professional networking into a habit using the Hook Model:

- Triggers: career progression anxiety (internal trigger) and notifications tied to user goals (e.g., “You’ve received 3 endorsements this week!”) (external trigger) prompt actions.
- Actions: quick, low-friction interactions like endorsing peers, sharing updates, and joining topic circles.

⁶ Howlett, M., & Mukherjee, I. (Eds.). (2018). Routledge handbook of policy design. Taylor & Francis Group.

⁷ Innerview. (2024, July 12). Hook Model Guide: Develop Habit-Forming Products. Innerview Insights Co. <https://innerview.co/blog/the-hook-model-creating-habit-forming-products-for-user-engagement/>

⁸ Benner, D., Schöbel, S. M., Janson, A., & Leimeister, J. (2022). How to Achieve Ethical Persuasive Design: A Review and Theoretical Propositions for Information Systems. AIS Transactions on Human-Computer Interaction, 14(4), 548-577. <https://doi.org/10.17705/1thci.00179> DOI: 10.17705/1thci.00179



- Variable Rewards: focused on Social Capital reinforcement (e.g., Recognition badges, reputation growth, or micro-credentials).
- Investment: The more users contribute (posts, mentorship), the higher their SCI, unlocking access to advanced analytics or curated opportunities.

This approach fosters intrinsic motivation through social validation and professional purpose, developing habitual participation without coercion and aligning behavioural reinforcement with ethical engagement.

2. Sphere – Ethical Immersion and Reflective Nudging

Sphere integrates Digital Nudging⁹ to guide sustainable decision-making while preserving user autonomy. Users receive real-time CO₂ avoidance metrics and gentle nudges (e.g., “Hosting this meeting virtually saves 350 kg of CO₂”). Unlike manipulative design (“dark patterns”¹⁰), Sphere provides opt-in transparency for all data use. By embedding reflective pauses and sustainability feedback, it encourages deliberate, rational (System 2¹¹) choices rather than impulsive ones.

3. Blueprint – Ethical Defaults and Triple-Layer Alignment

Blueprint employs the TLBMC to align persuasive design with ethical decision-making. It utilises Reduction (simplifying complex sustainability choices) and Tunnelling (guiding users through the necessary steps for planning a compliant event) to nudge users towards sustainable choices. At the same time, Blueprint sets ethical defaults (e.g., hybrid-first event design) while allowing users to reflect and override if needed. This approach exemplifies System 2 Nudging, promoting thoughtful, informed decision-making over passive compliance.

By integrating these frameworks, HorizonLink ensures that behavioural influence supports user autonomy, sustainability, and transparency to meet ethical standards while maintaining engagement efficiency.

6.3. User Stories

User stories illustrate how HorizonLink’s modules deliver tangible value to diverse users. They are supported by the Story Mapping (see Appendix G), which visualises sequential user activities and feature dependencies.

⁹ Beermann, V. (2025). The Three Waves of Digital Nudging: Concepts, Mechanisms, and Ethical Implications for Information Systems. AMCIS 2025 Proceedings, Canada, 24, 1-10. <https://aisel.aisnet.org/amcis2025/intelfuture/intelfuture/24>

¹⁰ Rawson, J., Umapathy, K., & Huang, H. (2025). Dark UI patterns in online shopping: Implications and conceptual framework. Proceedings of the Southern Association for Information Systems Conference, USA, 33. <https://aisel.aisnet.org/sais2025/33>

¹¹ Bhatt, E., & Seetharaman, P. (2023). Rethinking digital nudging: A taxonomical approach to defining and identifying characteristics of digital nudging interventions. AIS Transactions on Human-Computer Interaction, 15(4), 442-471. <https://doi.org/10.17705/1thci.00197>



User Story 1:

- Elle: “As an Early-career Academic, I want to grow my network and track my Social Capital Index, so I can measure my career growth and visibility without the financial or environmental cost of travel.”
- Outcome: Through the Hook Model, gamified recognition, and a peer endorsement system, Pulse enables Elle to engage daily, receiving micro-feedback and recognition, thereby transforming sporadic conference participation into measurable, continuous professional development.

User Story 2:

- Joyce: “As a Corporate Executive, I want to lead immersive global workshops that feel as real as in-person meetings, so I can enhance team collaboration while meeting ESG and carbon reduction targets.”
- Outcome: Sphere’s metaverse/XR environments and sustainability tracking dashboard allow Joyce to collaborate with international colleagues in realistic 3D settings, receiving automated carbon avoidance reports for sustainability disclosures.

6.4. Technological Implications

HorizonLink’s design is grounded in a cloud-native, API-first architecture, enabling modular integration, scalability, and cross-platform interoperability.

- **Architecture & Scalability:** A distributed microservices architecture ensures flexibility across modules. Single Sign-On (SSO) and unified dashboards allow seamless transitions between Pulse, Sphere, and Blueprint. Edge computing is employed to minimise latency during immersive sessions.
- **AI and Machine Learning Integration:** AI-driven personalisation curates content, detects engagement patterns, and updates each user’s SCI in real time. Machine Learning models predict relevant collaborations or “Circles” to join, optimising engagement while respecting user privacy.
- **Extended Reality (XR) and Metaverse Integration:** Sphere operates on a scalable XR infrastructure, delivering shared 3D environments, spatial audio, and avatar-based interaction. Built with inclusivity in mind, accessibility features (e.g., speech-to-text, adaptive visuals) ensure participation across abilities and devices.
- **Data Governance and Privacy:** HorizonLink complies with GDPR and ISO 27001 standards. Users maintain granular control over their data through transparent consent dashboards. All behavioural and performance analytics are anonymised and aggregated to prevent misuse.
- **Sustainability and Green Computing:** Data centres follow Green Computing standards, with renewable energy sourcing and carbon-offsetting mechanisms.



Blueprint's LCA engine quantifies the environmental impact of ICT use, ensuring net sustainability benefits are verifiable.

7. Growth Strategy

HorizonLink's growth strategy follows the Circle Mapping framework¹² (Appendix H), grounded in the Dynamic Capabilities theory of sensing emerging opportunities, seizing them through modular innovation, and transforming through new value networks. This phased model ensures an evolutionary, low-risk scaling path that leverages early adoption to fund and justify later expansion.

- **Initial Market: Professional Associations and Early-Career Academics**

The first phase (Pulse) targets professional associations and early-career academics in regions such as New Zealand and Australia. The value proposition of continuous engagement and measurable Social Capital growth addresses their need for affordable, credible, and low-carbon professional networking. HorizonLink will leverage partnerships with associations to seed a critical mass of users, demonstrating tangible engagement outcomes and network effects.

- **Next Market: Corporate Learning Divisions and Global Teams**

Once credibility and engagement data are established, the platform will scale to corporate clients and consulting firms through the Sphere module. This phase offers immersive, ethical collaboration and measurable sustainability impact, appealing to firms with ESG and Scope 3 reporting obligations. New capabilities will include advanced XR infrastructure and partnerships with sustainability analytics providers.

- **Future Market: MICE Industry, Governments, and Educational Institutions**

The final expansion (Blueprint) focuses on strategic sustainability management, helping organisations design low-carbon hybrid events and long-term TBL strategies. HorizonLink will transition into B2G and consulting services, licensing its analytics tools and advising on sustainable transformation policy.

This structured, evidence-led scaling approach balances risk and reward, ensuring HorizonLink grows sustainably from a trusted professional network to a systemic driver of global sustainable transformation.

8. Summary & Recommendations

HorizonLink presents a credible, high-impact digital transformation for the professional interaction industry. By combining behavioural science, sustainability analytics, and

¹² Bruni-Bossio, V., Sheehan, N.T., & Willness, C.R. (2018). Circle mapping your firm's growth strategy. *Business Horizons*, 61(2), 285—296. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.bushor.2017.11.010>



platform innovation, it redefines how professionals build trust, collaborate, and measure progress in a low-carbon economy.

The platform delivers measurable TBL benefits across economic, environmental, and social layers. Professionals, associations, employers, and the planet all stand to gain from this redesign. The three-phase structure - Pulse, Sphere, and Blueprint - ensures scalable growth while maintaining ethical design and verifiable sustainability outcomes.

Key Recommendations:

1. Fund and launch Phase 1 (Pulse) immediately through partnerships with professional associations and impact investors to establish critical mass and trust.
2. Prioritise the SCI and transparent data governance as early differentiators.
3. Scale to corporate clients (Sphere) once network effects and credibility are demonstrated, using measurable sustainability outcomes as market proof.
4. Expand into strategic analytics (Blueprint) and consulting for governments and the MICE industry, consolidating HorizonLink's leadership in sustainable professional transformation.

This staged roadmap converts the financial and environmental cost of traditional travel into inclusive, aligning profit with purpose and positioning HorizonLink as a global standard for sustainable professional connection.

Generative AI Use Statement:

Notebook LM was used to summarise and extract key theories and frameworks from course readings for study purposes. The author manually reviewed and applied these concepts in the case analysis.

Gemini was used to generate prototype sketches of each HorizonLink module based on the author's prompts. The outputs were reviewed and manually refined to ensure accuracy and alignment with the intended design vision.

ChatGPT was used to improve the structure, coherence, and clarity of the business case draft. All AI suggestions were critically reviewed and revised by the author before inclusion.

Grammarly was used to identify language and grammar issues, which were subsequently reviewed and corrected by the author to maintain academic integrity.



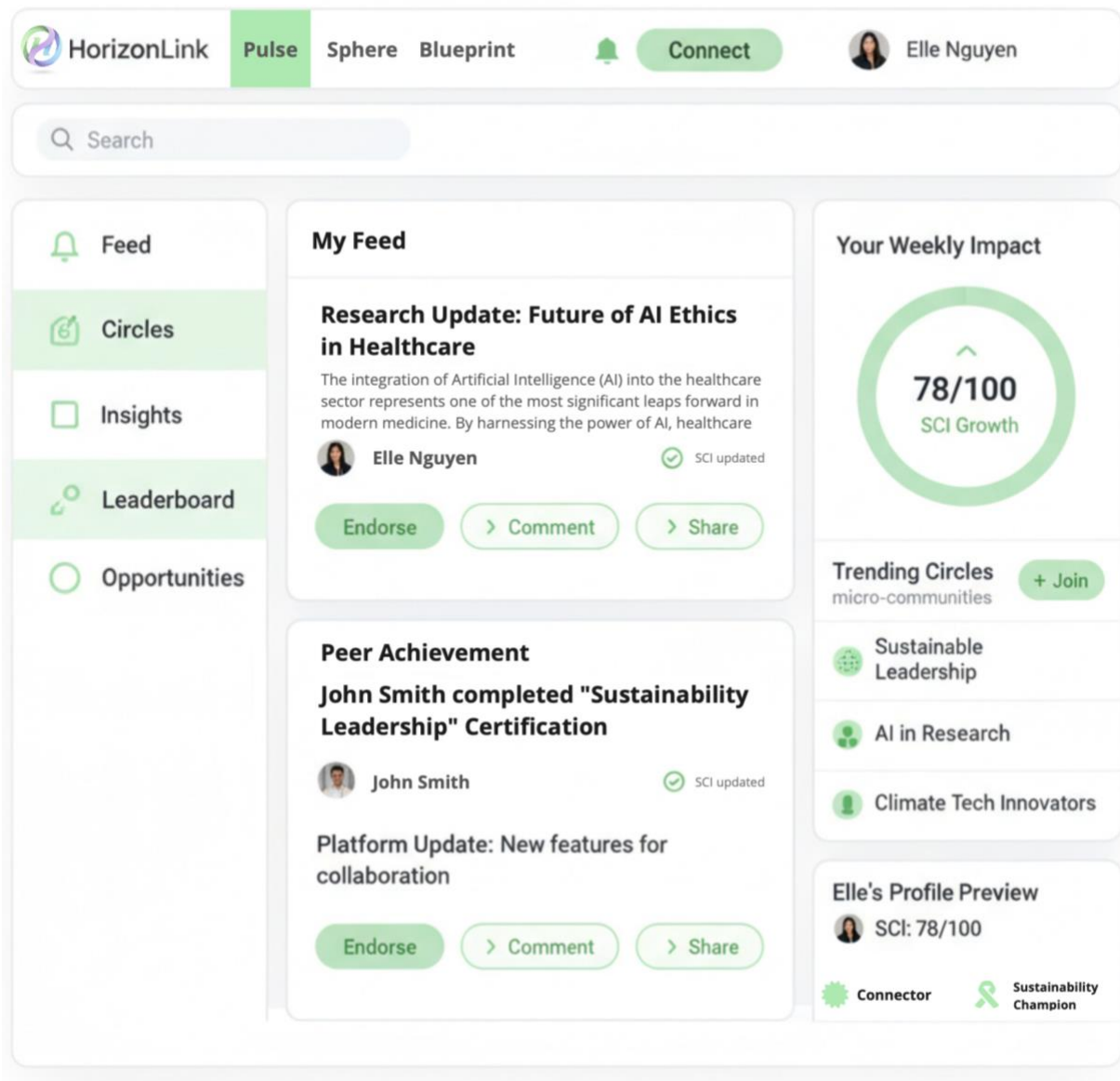
Appendices

Appendix A. HorizonLink's Business Model Canvas



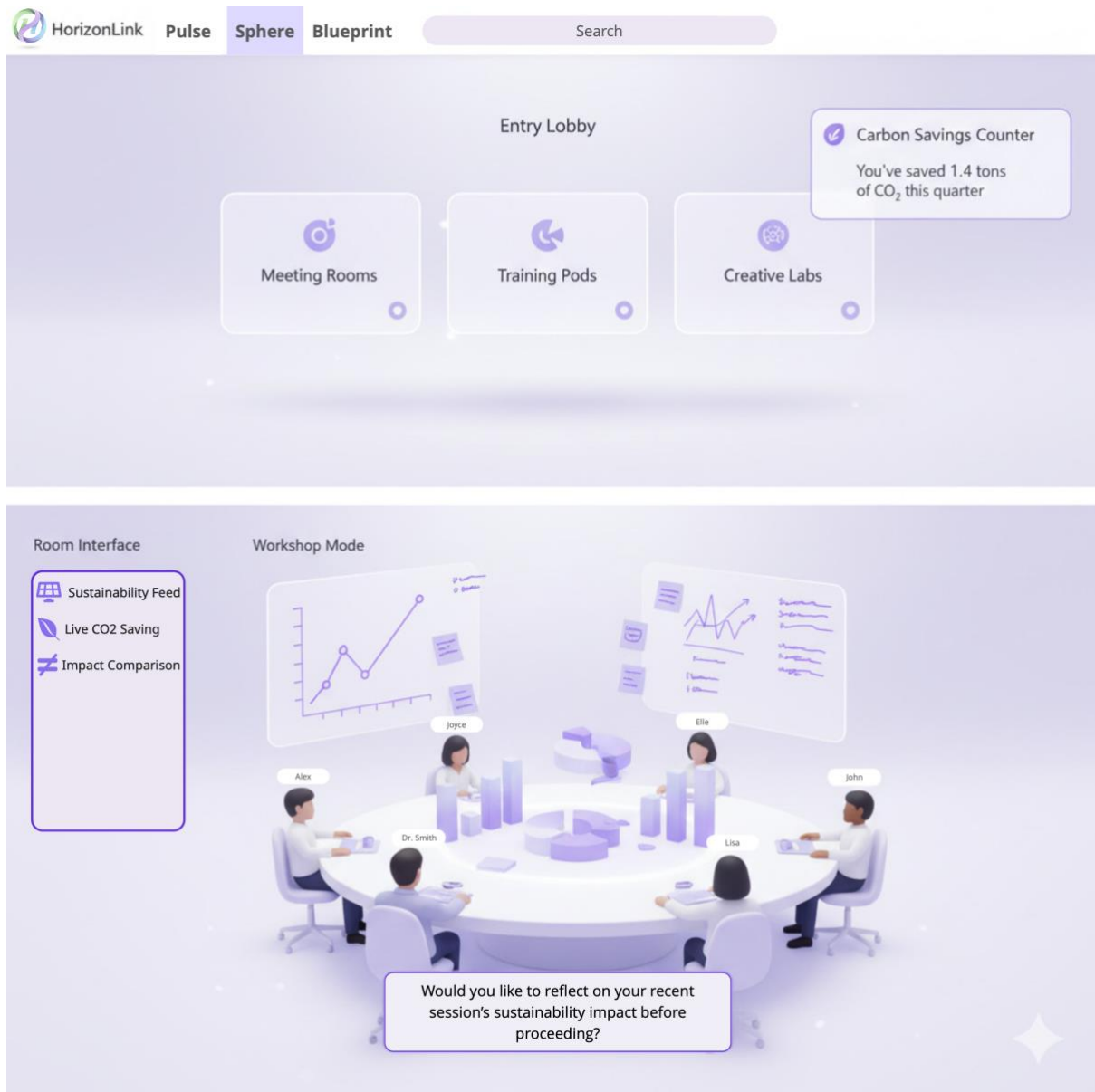


Appendix B. Platform Prototype Sketch of Pulse - Continuous Engagement Platform



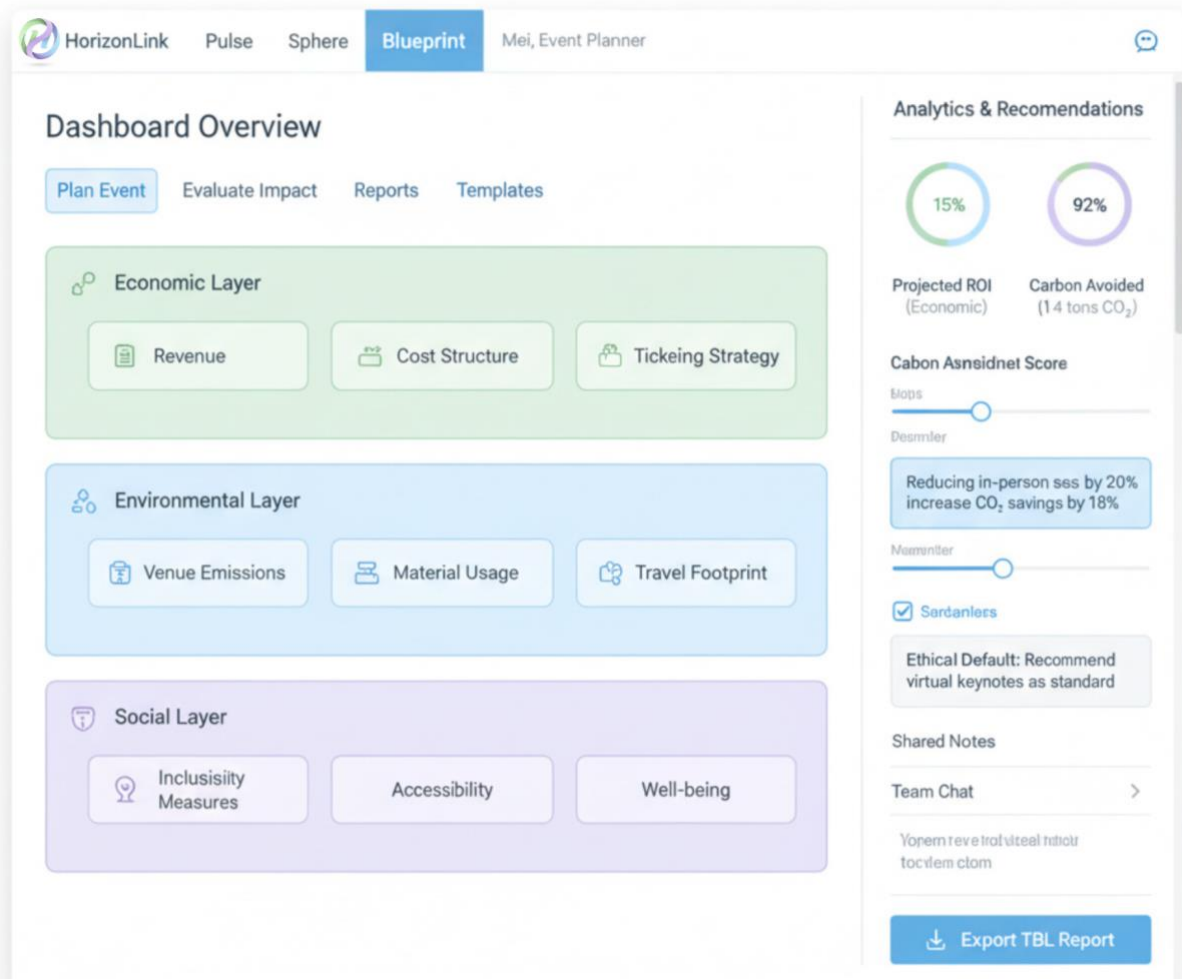


Appendix C. Platform Prototype Sketch of Sphere - Immersive Collaboration Environment





Appendix D. Platform Prototype Sketch of Blueprint - Hybrid Event Optimisation Engine





Appendix E. User Personas of Target Customers

Meet Elle, The Early Career Academic

Demographics

Age 29
Lecturer at VUW
PhD in Environmental
Science
Lives in Wellington

HorizonLink Solution

Pulse provides ongoing micro-interactions, endorsements, and analytics to track her growing influence ("Social Capital Score"), helping her demonstrate measurable progress without costly travel.

Goals

- Gain visibility for her research and connect with global scholars.
- Build measurable "social capital" for tenure and funding applications.
- Access affordable, meaningful engagement throughout the year.

Needs

A credible digital environment that quantifies professional reputation and supports continuous career growth.

Opportunities

Wants to establish an international academic presence and network with peers globally, without needing to attend expensive overseas conferences.

Barriers & Frustrations

- Travel costs and limited institutional funding.
- Weak networking value in traditional virtual events.
- Lack of systems recognising online contributions as professional impact.

Observations & Task

She finds virtual conferences impersonal and non-interactive. Her main task is to connect with peers and demonstrate influence in measurable ways.

A-ha Moments

She realises that consistent micro-engagements through Pulse build more authentic connections than occasional in-person events.

Meet Joyce, The Association Executive

Demographics

Age 42
Executive Director,
Australasian Professional
Society
Based in Sydney

HorizonLink Solution

Pulse keeps members connected, while Blueprint visualises engagement and sustainability outcomes across all activities, giving Jocelyn credible data for her board reports.

Goals

- Keep members engaged between annual conferences.
- Report measurable progress on sustainability.
- Strengthen the society's digital presence.

Needs

An integrated platform that maintains professional community engagement and provides transparent sustainability metrics.

Opportunities

Wants to increase member retention and attract younger professionals while meeting sustainability commitments.

Barriers & Frustrations

- Declining membership renewals post-pandemic.
- Limited visibility of member engagement data.
- Pressures to demonstrate environmental responsibility.

Observations & Task

She struggles with event fatigue and disengaged members. Her task is to sustain active membership between major events.

A-ha Moments

She realises that digital engagement doesn't have to replace events but can extend and deepen member relationships year-round.



Meet Dr. Smith , The Corporate Strategist

Demographics

Age 48
Global Strategy Director,
Consulting Firm
Based in Singapore

HorizonLink Solution

Sphere provides immersive, secure environments for virtual meetings with real-time Carbon Avoidance Metrics, enabling accurate ESG reporting and strategic advantage.



Goals

- Enable global teams to collaborate seamlessly in real-time.
- Quantify the sustainability impact of reduced business travel.
- Report on carbon avoidance as part of ESG disclosures.

Needs

A high-fidelity virtual workspace that supports trust, creativity, and measurable environmental reporting.

Opportunities

Seeks to improve team collaboration and innovation outcomes while meeting ESG targets.

Barriers & Frustrations

- Inconsistent remote collaboration tools.
- Difficulty maintaining team engagement virtually.
- Increasing stakeholder pressure for transparent ESG reporting.

Observations & Task

Dr. Smith manages distributed teams and must demonstrate both performance and sustainability value.

A-ha Moments

He realises that immersive digital collaboration can strengthen trust and reduce emissions simultaneously.

Meet Mei, The Hybrid Event Planner

Demographics

Age 36
Event Manager,
Asia-Pacific MICE firm
Based in Auckland

HorizonLink Solution

Blueprint helps Mei visualize CO₂ savings, participation equity, and profitability in one dashboard, ensuring decisions align with the Triple Bottom Line.



Goals

- Plan hybrid conferences with measurable TBL outcomes.
- Balance cost efficiency, inclusivity, and sustainability.
- Demonstrate innovation leadership in event design.

Needs

A data-driven tool that models and compares the environmental, economic, and social impacts of event formats.

Opportunities

Wants to design engaging, cost-effective hybrid events for diverse clients that align with sustainability goals.

Barriers & Frustrations

- Complex logistics between physical and virtual formats.
- Lack of clear sustainability benchmarks.
- Client skepticism about hybrid event quality.

Observations & Task

She spends hours manually estimating carbon and cost trade-offs.

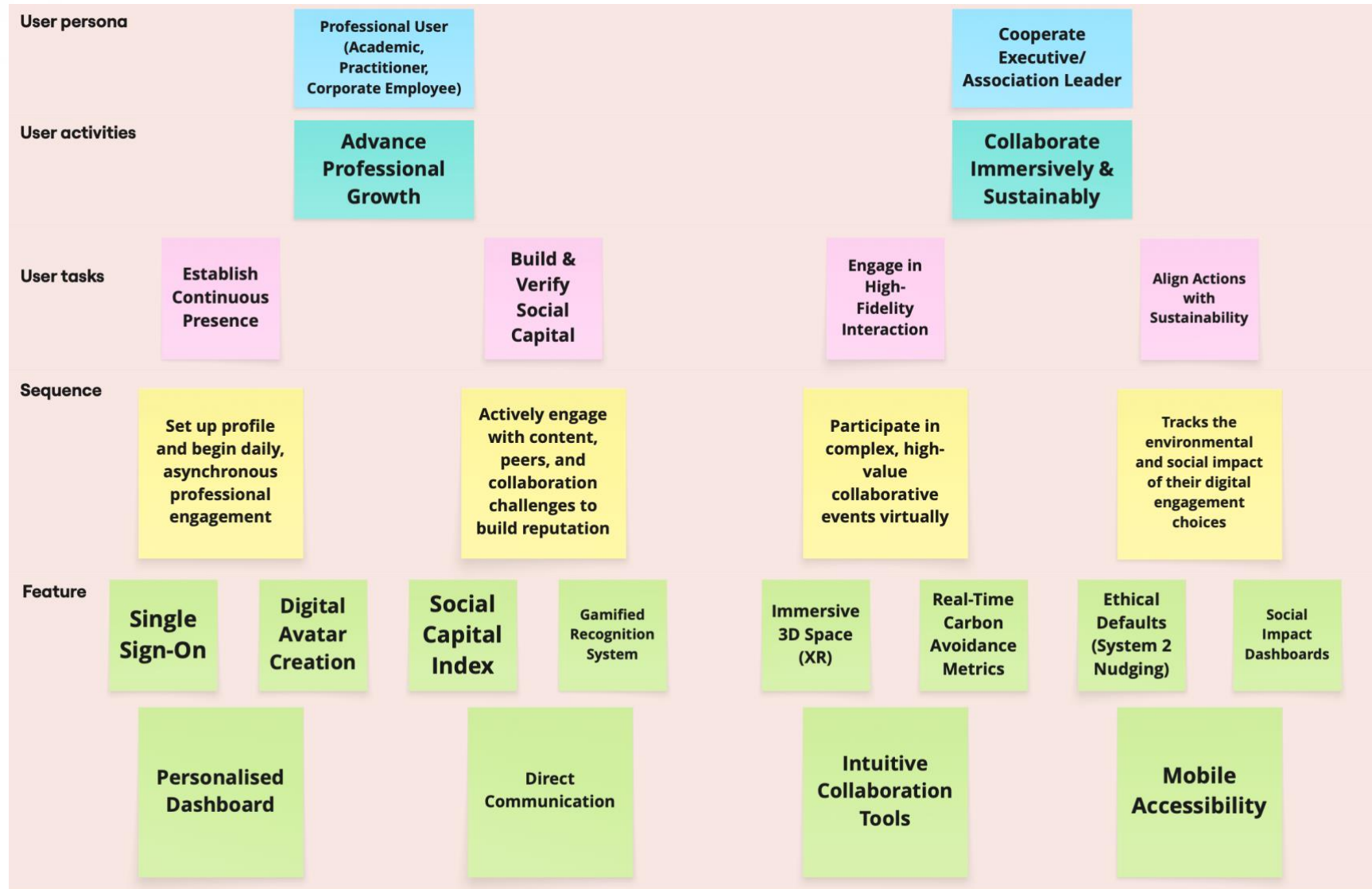
A-ha Moments

She realises that Blueprint's analytics can guide decisions that meet both budget and sustainability targets.





Appendix G. User Story Mapping





Appendix H. Circle Mapping Framework for Growth Strategy Planning

Circle	Target Customers	Value Proposition	Resources/Capabilities Required	Risks	Rewards	Scaling Strategy
Current	Professional Associations, Early-career Professionals	Continuous engagement, measurable Social Capital (Pulse)	Platform UX, analytics, behavioural design	Limited adoption risk	Strong community base, data validation	Association pilots, local networks
Next	Corporate, Global Teams	Immersive collaboration, measurable sustainability (Sphere)	XR/Metaverse infrastructure, ESG data integration	Technical costs, market education	Premium B2B revenue, ESG compliance leadership	Leverage success data to attract enterprise clients
Future	Governments, MICE Industry, Universities	Strategic sustainability analytics, hybrid optimisation (Blueprint)	Consulting expertise, TLBMC framework, policy partnerships	Regulatory complexity, long sales cycle	Thought leadership, systemic transformation	Expand into B2G consulting and sustainability strategy

